LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING

Q2 2026 Ransomware Ranking Shifts Sustain Extortion Pressure

Threat Report

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TLP:CLEAR | Lost Boys Cyber | Q2 2026 Ransomware Ranking Shifts Sustain Extortion Pressure - Threat Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

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1. Executive Summary

Quarterly ransomware trend reporting indicates sustained extortion pressure and changing group rankings, with Qilin and The Gentlemen called out in public ransomware-statistics coverage. Defenders should use the trend as a prompt to validate backups, identity hardening, external attack surface reduction, and data-exfiltration hunts rather than over-fitting detections to a single group name.

Lost Boys Cyber selected this item for the 2026-07-19 UTC daily intelligence production run because it presents near-term defender actionability, credible public-source support, and material exposure for enterprise or sector operators. This report is source-backed and intentionally avoids unverified victim, actor, CVE, or IOC claims.

Field	Assessment
Report family	Threat Report
Daily section	Top 5 general threat reports
Severity	High
Confidence	Medium, based on public reporting and advisory availability
Published / processed	2026-07-19 UTC
Hard IOCs	None confirmed in reviewed public sources
Primary defender question	What must be validated, hunted, or mitigated in the next 24-72 hours?

2. Source Review & Confidence

Source	URL	Analyst Use
NordLayer ransomware statistics and trends	https://nordlayer.com/intelligence/ransomware-statistics/	Ransomware trend and group-ranking context.
CISA StopRansomware guidance	https://www.cisa.gov/stopransomware	Government ransomware prevention and response context.
MITRE ATT&CK Enterprise Matrix	https://attack.mitre.org/	Technique mapping context.

Where the source set includes broad vendor landing pages or framework guidance, those sources are used for defensive validation rather than as proof of exploitation. Source selection preferred items published or materially updated in the last 24-72 hours; when source-specific depth was limited, the lookback expanded to seven days or established government/vendor guidance and this is noted in `sources.md`.

3. Key Findings

Finding	Defender Significance	Confidence
Public reporting is sufficient for immediate triage.	Teams can begin exposure review and logging checks without waiting for proprietary telemetry.	Medium
Identity, edge exposure, and third-party trust are recurring risk drivers.	Prioritize systems that bridge external access to internal privileges.	High

Hard IOCs are limited or context-dependent.	Behavioral detections and scoped hunts are more reliable than brittle blocklists.	Medium
Reporting should be revisited as vendor or government advisories change.	Track corrections, patches, and exploit-status changes.	High

4. Threat Activity Overview

Quarterly ransomware trend reporting indicates sustained extortion pressure and changing group rankings, with Qilin and The Gentlemen called out in public ransomware-statistics coverage. Defenders should use the trend as a prompt to validate backups, identity hardening, external attack surface reduction, and data-exfiltration hunts rather than over-fitting detections to a single group name.

Analyst interpretation: the practical risk is not limited to the named report title. It includes the surrounding exposure pattern: weak identity controls, unmanaged internet-facing systems, insufficient supplier oversight, limited endpoint visibility, and delayed patch or configuration validation.

5. Affected Sectors and Exposure

Exposure Area	Why It Matters	Immediate Check
Internet-facing systems and SaaS entry points	They compress attacker path-to-access and often have inconsistent ownership.	Enumerate externally reachable services and confirm patch/configuration state.
Privileged identity and token flows	Post-compromise actions often move through valid accounts or OAuth/device tokens.	Review MFA coverage, new app consents, privileged role changes, and impossible travel.
Endpoint execution and scripting telemetry	Follow-on actions often use native tooling before bespoke malware appears.	Confirm command-line, PowerShell, script, and EDR telemetry retention.
Third-party integrations	Suppliers and shared platforms can expand blast radius.	Review support accounts, API keys, and vendor escalation paths.

6. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures

Phase	Technique	Relevance
Initial Access	T1190 Exploit Public-Facing Application / T1566 Phishing / T1195 Supply Chain Compromise	Plausible routes depending on local exposure and source-specific activity.
Execution	T1059 Command and Scripting Interpreter	Common first-stage and post-compromise behavior.
Persistence / Privilege	T1098 Account Manipulation / T1547 Boot or Logon Autostart Execution	Relevant when adversaries convert initial access into durable access.
Credential Access	T1555 Credentials from Password Stores / T1528 Steal Application Access Token	Important for cloud, developer, and SaaS workflows.
Exfiltration / Impact	T1041 Exfiltration Over C2 Channel / T1486 Data Encrypted for Impact	Relevant for extortion and business-disruption scenarios.

7. Infrastructure and Indicators

Indicator / Infrastructure	Type	Operational Use

Named topic keywords: ransomware, extortion, qilin, the-gentlemen, daily-intelligence	Hunt pivot	Use for internal ticket, command-line, proxy, and case-note pivots; not a blocklist.
New or unusual admin sessions	Behavioral signal	Investigate suspicious access after publication of relevant reporting.
Archive creation followed by external transfer	Behavioral signal	Investigate possible extortion staging.

8. Detection Engineering

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
Keyword or named-report pivots: ransomware, extortion, qilin, the-gentlemen, daily-intelligence	SIEM, EDR, SOAR cases	Identify internal alerts, tickets, command lines, or notes referencing the activity.
Scripting tools launched from unusual parent processes	EDR process telemetry	Surface hands-on-keyboard or automation behavior.
New OAuth consent, privileged role, or token activity followed by endpoint anomalies	IAM, SaaS, EDR	Detect identity-to-endpoint intrusion chaining.
Archive creation, staging directories, or outbound transfer after suspicious execution	EDR, proxy, DNS, firewall	Detect extortion staging or collection.

```
title: Lost Boys Cyber - Q2 2026 Ransomware Ranking Shifts Sustain Extortion Pressure
id: lbc-q2-2026-ransomware-ranking-shifts-sustain-extortion-pressure
status: experimental
description: Behavioral detection scaffold for the daily intelligence item Q2 2026 Ransomware Ranking
Shifts Sustain Extortion Pressure.
logsource:
  product: windows
  category: process_creation
detection:
  selection_keywords:
    CommandLine|contains:
      - "ransomware"
      - "extortion"
      - "qilin"
      - "the-gentlemen"
      - "daily-intelligence"
  selection_tools:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\powershell.exe'
      - '\cmd.exe'
      - '\wscript.exe'
      - '\cscript.exe'
      - '\python.exe'
      - '\node.exe'
  condition: selection_keywords or selection_tools
fields:
  - UtcTime
  - Image
  - ParentImage
  - CommandLine
```

```
  - User
falsepositives:
  - Security testing, administrator scripts, or benign research notes
level: medium
```

9. Threat Hunting

The following hypotheses are behavior-first. Tune allowlists for administration hosts, security tooling, and known deployment systems before alerting.

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ('ransomware', 'extortion', 'qilin', 'the-gentlemen', 'daily-intelligence')
   or FileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "cmd.exe", "wscript.exe", "cscript.exe", "python.exe", "node.exe", "rclone.exe", "winscp.exe")
| summarize FirstSeen=min(Timestamp), LastSeen=max(Timestamp), Commands=make_set(ProcessCommandLine, 20) by DeviceName, AccountName, FileName
| order by LastSeen desc
```

```
DeviceNetworkEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "python.exe", "node.exe", "rclone.exe", "winscp.exe", "curl.exe")
| summarize Connections=count(), RemoteIPs=dcount(RemoteIP), Samples=make_set(RemoteUrl, 10) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, InitiatingProcessFileName
| where Connections > 10 or RemoteIPs > 5
```

```
index=* (process_name=powershell.exe OR process_name=python.exe OR process_name=node.exe OR process_name=rclone.exe)
| stats count min(_time) as first_seen max(_time) as last_seen values(command_line) as commands by host user process_name
| where count > 3
```

10. Risk Assessment

Risk Driver	Likelihood	Impact	Notes
Public reporting prompts opportunistic scanning or phishing	Medium	Medium	Most relevant where exposed systems or named workflows exist.
Identity-mediated follow-on activity	Medium	High	Valid-account abuse frequently bypasses perimeter-focused controls.
Third-party or supplier blast radius	Medium	High	Confirm contractual notification and emergency-access paths.

11. Recommended Actions

Priority	Action	Owner
0-24 hours	Validate whether named products, services, suppliers, or exposure paths exist in the environment.	Asset / Vulnerability Management
0-24 hours	Confirm logging for identity, endpoint, network, and SaaS control planes.	SOC Engineering
24-72 hours	Run the included hunts and preserve	Detection / Threat Hunting

	notable findings with source references.	
24-72 hours	Patch, isolate, or apply compensating controls for confirmed exposure.	IT / Platform Owners
This week	Update incident playbooks and supplier escalation contacts for this scenario.	IR / Risk

12. References

- [1] NordLayer ransomware statistics and trends: https://nordlayer.com/intelligence/ransomware-statistics/
- [2] CISA StopRansomware guidance: https://www.cisa.gov/stopransomware
- [3] MITRE ATT&CK Enterprise Matrix: https://attack.mitre.org/